people engaged in the task.

Others say the genesis of the controversy perhaps lay in the tweaking of the tendering process that prescribes vendor verification norms by the TTD Board in December 2019 and February 2020 when Y.V. Subba Reddy, Rajya Sabha member and Jagan's maternal uncle, was the chairperson. Those changes, apparently made so as to welcome more bidders to the tendering process, led to less stringent conditions like the operational qualification of dairies intending to supply ghee (collecting 400,000 litres of cow milk a day) and company turnover (reduced from Rs 250 crore to Rs 150 crore with the audited balance sheet for one year instead of three years earlier). While these norms were for dairies outside Andhra Pradesh, the ones for within the state were even more relaxed.

The TTD also introduced the reverse auction tendering process, whereby those who had bid higher could supply at the same price as the lowest bidder. Critics say this was a perilous path—the obsession with the relative lower price may have meant inadequate attention to factors like quality, flexibility and on-time delivery. In its defence, the TTD cited the need for at least 15,000 kg of ghee a day. An earlier norm that only dairies within a 1,200 km radius were eligible was also glossed over. Subba Reddy was appointed by Jagan when he became CM in 2019, and continued till 2023. He is also among those who have petitioned the Supreme Court for an independent inquiry by a retired judge. "I am ready to take an oath before the deity, and challenge Naidu to do the same if he truly believes in his accusations," says the former TTD chairman.

BATTLE FOR TEMPLE CONTROL

Interestingly, when the Tirupati laddoo incident exploded, the VHP was holding a regional meeting in the town (on September 23) attended by seers from both the Telugu-speaking states, Andhra Pradesh and Telangana. It was decided there that street protests were not the answer, what was needed was a concerted effort to bring changes in the law to "free Hindu temples" from government control.

Indeed, a large section in the Sangh believes that state governments and their bureaucrats misuse the funds collected by temples.

POLITICAL ANALYSTS WARN THAT THE ISSUE GOES BEYOND POLITICS. IT INVOLVES RELIGIOUS SENSITIVITIES AND COULD LEAD TO UNREST IF FANNED

VHP national joint general secretary Surendra Jain advocates a "socialisation of temples" to replace the current "governmentalisation". He believes that governments keeping control of the temples is a continuation of the mindset of the "Muslim invaders" and the "colonial British". Since the beginning of Modi 2.0 in 2019, the Sangh affiliates had been aggressive about getting the BJP to take control of temple boards.

In 2021, pressure from the VHP and RSS had forced the Pushkar Singh Dhami government in Uttarakhand to disband the Char Dham Devasthanam Board—which had been set up on the lines of the TTD Board. The big temples the Sangh is now focusing

PROOF OF CREDENTIALS

UP restarts policy of requiring owners to display their names outside eateries despite fears that this will encourage discrimination

Two months after the Supreme Court stayed a police order in Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand asking eateries on the Kanwar yatra route to display the names of owners, UP is taking a circuitous route to bring it up again. Broadening the focus to food adulteration, the government has issued a statement, asking that 'necessary amendments be made in the Food Safety and Standards Act to ensure compliance in this regard'. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath has also ordered all food establishments to instal CCTV cameras. A statewide verification process will also be started soon by a joint team of the Food Safety and Drug Administration (FSDA), police and local administration to make sure that compliance is total.

As in the previous instance, the Opposition and civil society have reacted sharply to the move, calling it a strategy to divert people's attention from real issues while also harassing the poor and minority businesses. UP Congress president Ajay Rai says, "The BJP had tried the same move in the holy month of Sawan. This only confirms the fact that CM Yogi is trying to divert people's attention